

ChatGPT is overhated, especially under the guise of "environmental concerns"

Posted by u/XontroPossum • 0 points • 16 comments

Honestly, I just care about people's opinions on this... I would love to get a discussion going, personally im a research student in STEM and I dont know what I would have done without chatGPT... it helps me digest papers, methods and maths almost like having a tutor next to me 24/7 and honestly I dont think it receives the praise that it deserves in the world. I genuinely believe that chatGPT, indirectly, will aid researchers advance science in faster rates! All opinions welcome btw, im curious about both sides on this!

Comments

u/Working-Contract-948 • 2 points • 2025-08-09 05:27 UTC

Its environmental impact is so unremarkable versus basically anything else humans do at scale that anyone making this argument should be dismissed as knowing nothing and not having thought about it at all.

u/SunstoneFV • 2 points • 2025-08-09 17:41 UTC

To make a comparison concerning water use.

One pound of beef raised commercially in the US uses 1,800 and 2,200 gallons of water. That's equivalent to 21,176,471 to 25,882,353 queries using ChatGPT. A 3.25 pound family pack of ground beef at the grocery store? As much water as 84,000,000 ChatGPT queries.

u/Audio-Weasel • 1 points • 2025-08-09 04:40 UTC

Haha, environmental concerns... In an age where our 'safe for the environment' cars are not repairable in the longterm forcing unnecessary new purchases. In an age where nothing is repairable, really. So much talk about environment this and environment that and many products are quite literally designed to fail over time, with no way to repair or replace batteries.

Oh, and is it true that Bitcoin mining requires enough energy to power all of Poland?

Lastly -- these AI companies bring the processing burden on themselves. There's no reason we shouldn't be able to do the processing on our local PCs, except *they want the control* on their end.

No, local processing wouldn't change the 'collective environmental impact' --- but it would certainly free up their processing time.

And regardless of the downvotes and excuses of why that would be impossible, there's a way to do it if they wanted it to be done.

But they don't.

u/Working-Contract-948 • 2 points • 2025-08-09 05:35 UTC

You can't run a model with half a trillion parameters locally on hardware in the same galaxy as what the average user possesses. Come off it.

u/Audio-Weasel • 1 points • 2025-08-09 05:57 UTC

Average user is one thing, but in the category of people who can afford premium tier AI subscriptions -- a lot of us have very powerful PCs, whether gamers with ridiculously powerful machines for that stuff or whether developers who make the software.

It's not an exact comparison, but some people like Google Docs in the Cloud and others like offline tools that tend to have fewer cloud based limitations.

In audio there are elementary studios running Bandlab in their browsers, and professionals running Pro Tools on rigs capable of hundreds of audio tracks and effects.

And heck, even YouTuber types require high end machines for all the video production work.

It's just not that uncommon to have a pretty high end PC.

If you count the hundreds of thousands or millions of people using AI -- there's certainly a lot of processing that could be done on an individual PC, even if it wouldn't have the immediate cloud connectivity of live service, etc.

u/Working-Contract-948 • 2 points • 2025-08-09 06:08 UTC

Dude, please just look up the requirements for running (say) DeepSeek-V3 at a barely-adequate TPS. You are not talking about a "high-end PC," you are talking about something more like "a rack of servers." It's completely unreasonable for almost all users.

u/Audio-Weasel • 2 points • 2025-08-09 06:13 UTC

If I'm wrong then I appreciate you taking the time to correct my ignorance. (sincerely)

I understand the storage issue. That one I can wrap my head around -- the seemingly limitless amount of archived knowledge these tools draw from is incredible.

But processing power?

If it requires THAT much, how can they possibly handle so many users at once?

u/Working-Contract-948 • 2 points • 2025-08-09 06:21 UTC

The short answer is that they use heavily-optimized and enormously-expensive hardware at gigantic scale. Also, the memory footprint scales as a small multiple of concurrent users: the same model-in-memory can be used for many users at once, and when a user is done using it their slot can be allocated to someone else. Users running locally-hosted LLMs don't get these economies of scale.

u/Audio-Weasel • 2 points • 2025-08-09 06:31 UTC

Thank you. That makes sense. I'm looking into locally hosted LLMs right now, but I'm keeping my expectations low.

u/Working-Contract-948 • 1 points • 2025-08-09 06:41 UTC

I've heard good things about Google Gemma, but yeah, you shouldn't expect to get the performance you'd get out of a platform model. Check out Ollama if you want a simple way to get started locally, though. Limitations aside, it is fun.

u/v • 2 points • 2025-08-09 06:41 UTC

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u/CruciolsMade4Muggles • 1 points • 2025-08-09 04:05 UTC

Running a single prompt through GPT 4o consumes 1/2 a liter of water. The environmental concerns are valid.

u/Working-Contract-948 • 1 points • 2025-08-09 05:32 UTC

It absolutely does not consume 500ml (1/2 liter) of water. It "consumes" on the order of 5ml, if not substantially less. You're off by literally two orders of magnitude. Also, what does it mean for water to be "consumed"? Do you think it's being annihilated? Do you know how much water it takes to grow a peanut?

u/CruciolsMade4Muggles • 1 points • 2025-08-09 05:45 UTC

Water consumption has a well defined meaning: conversation from liquid to vapor state. It's a stand-in value for joules of power.

And yes, it does consume 500 ml.

u/XontroPossum • 3 points • 2025-08-09 04:35 UTC

Valid, but I think it's a bit hypocritical to parrot anti-GPT talking points when our overall online habits are just as harmful, if not worse. Scrolling TikTok uses about 0.27 liters of water per minute, and streaming Netflix in HD for 1 hour uses 50 liters, yet no one is rallying against binge-watching or endless doom scrolling. Meanwhile, GPT is actively helping educate people and improve work across fields... so lowkey If we're serious about environmental trade-offs, entertainment and streaming should be the first thing being critisized and on the chopping block.

u/Working-Contract-948 • 1 points • 2025-08-09 05:34 UTC

It's not valid; the 0.5 liter number is complete nonsense, and even if it weren't, it's so low in comparison to other human activities as to be meaningless.

u/CruciolsMade4Muggles • 0 points • 2025-08-09 04:44 UTC

Steaming Netflix doesn't use 50 liters in 1 hour. I'm not sure where you got that bunk ass number from. Don't know about Tiktok, but I'm skeptical on that number as well.

u/XontroPossum • 1 points • 2025-08-09 04:54 UTC

Honestly i may be bullshiting you, but not intentionally... this is where i had read it https://cwrrr.org/resources/analysis-reviews/tis-the-season-to-be-worried-our-online-habits/?utm_source=chatgpt.com and this was the paragraph: "Although Netflix has announced its commitment to reach net zero GHG emissions [by the end of 2022](https://about.netflix.com/en/news/net-zero-nature-our-climate-commitment), it has no commitment to reduce its water consumption. In 2018, we found out that streaming Netflix in HD for 4 hours in Australia was equivalent to [using 200 litres of water] (https://cwrrr.org/resources/analysis-reviews/youtube-the-dark-side-of-going-viral/), whereas every Google search takes [1 spoonful of water](https://cwrrr.org/resources/analysis-reviews/youtube-the-dark-side-of-going-viral/). The typical data centre uses [3 – 5 million gallons of water per day] (https://www.morningbrew.com/emerging-tech/stories/2021/10/29/data-centers-can-use-as-much-water-as-a-small-town-microsoft-just-pledged-to-slash-that) to cool and power its servers – equivalent to the water consumption of a city with 30 – 50k people." I may be misinterpreting something OR maybe this website is not like credible?? I dont know i dont swear by it!

u/NurseWizzle • 1 points • 2025-08-09 04:33 UTC

ChatGPT is thirsty

u/AutoModerator • 1 points • 2025-08-09 04:04 UTC

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If your post is a DALL-E 3 image post, please reply with the prompt used to make this image.

Consider joining our [public discord server](https://discord.gg/r-chatgpt-1050422060352024636)! We have free bots with GPT-4 (with vision), image generators, and more!

🤖

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